

Use the “Five Whys” Technique to Get to the Root of Your Money Beliefs

Toyota pioneered the Five Whys Technique to improve its manufacturing system. When something went wrong, like a defect in a bumper, they’d ask “Why?” over and over to get to the real root cause, which wasn’t always obvious. We can use the same technique when you feel frustrated with money, like this:

1. “Whenever I spend money, it makes me feel bad.” Why?
 2. “Because I feel guilty about spending money. I know I should save more.” Why?
 3. “Because I don’t think I’ll have enough money to be safe.” Why?
 4. “Because, well . . . I guess I don’t know what ‘enough’ or ‘safe’ means. I never really defined it. Maybe it’s not even a number.” Why?
 5. “Because growing up, I saw my parents struggle.” Why?
- Root Cause: “There was never enough—and I never want to end up like them.”

I’ve spoken to thousands of people who believe that a certain number will make them feel safe, but when we go through this exercise, they realize that no number will change the way they feel—*because their money belief isn’t actually about the number. It’s a feeling.* Once you get to the root cause of your frustration, then you’ll have a clearer idea of how to fix it.